

Heading generally southeast toward Savannah, the army advanced in two columns, staying 20–40 miles (32–64km) apart. They carried supplies with them but intended to live off the land. Each brigade was allotted its share of the army's 2,500 supply wagons along with its own party of foragers, or "bummers." Sherman had given his forces strict instructions in the form of his "Special Field Orders, No. 120." The order gave broad freedom in the requisitioning of horses, mules, forage, and provisions, but expressly forbade entering civilians' property or using "abusive or threatening language" to householders. If, passing through any given district, the army was unopposed, mills, cotton gins, and homesteads were not to be destroyed. If opposed, however, commanders should impose "a devastation more or less relentless." But the rules were not enforced. In fact, the two columns gauged each other's position by the pillars of smoke on the horizon: burnings marked their progress.

It might have been the war's most roguish march were it not for its punitive intent. In Milledgeville, Georgia's capital, the invading army held a mock session of the legislature in the abandoned chambers, repealing the ordinance of secession. Sherman slept that night in the Governor's pillared mansion, but in his own camp bed because all the furniture had been hidden. The soldiers destroyed railroads, ripping up tracks and twisting them into "Sherman neckties." They devoured all livestock in their path. They stripped farms of all their forage and root crops. They burned barns, corncribs, cotton gins, houses, and once an entire town. Coming across Camp Lawton, a prisoner-of-war stockade, the veterans were so enraged by the brutalities they found that Sherman ordered nearby Millen to be destroyed with "ten-fold" times the usual measure. As the Union army advanced over a front nearly 60 miles (97km) wide, all the South could do was narrow the zone of destruction.